

Minister of TANTR

The highly volatile railways minister's Bengal-First attitude puts the UPA Government in a tight spot

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

As Ram Vilas Paswan came to the end of his Railway Budget speech in February 1997, an irate Mamata Banerjee, then a member of Parliament from Congress, flung her black shawl at the minister for not giving enough to West Bengal. Walking out of the Lok Sabha, she announced her resignation. It was always Bengal First for her. Though a mediating Santosh Mohan Deb brought about a temporary truce, it did not last long. A few months later, Banerjee walked out of the Congress for good and formed her own party, the Trinamool Congress. The leader of the second largest party in the UPA alliance has now become a headache for the Government.

The Congress has never found it easy to handle the mercurial Banerjee who, with a tally of 19 MPs, knows that she is indispensable. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh has had to step in to deal with the volatile railways minister, sometimes to ask her to focus on her ministry and on other occasions to simply cool down. "She has to be handled like an errant child by explaining, cajoling and showing strictness at times. Only the mild-mannered prime minister has the wherewithal to do it," says a senior government official.

With complaints against her growing and Banerjee becoming politically more demanding, the prime minister had to send an eight-page letter to her, reminding her the "problems facing the Indian Railways" and also suggesting solutions (see box). He asked her for a report, saying that he expected immediate consideration of

